



Snapchat to Spectacles

How AR's powering Snap's India growth story

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“It’s all about unlocking creativity and self-expression, changing how we see ourselves and the world,” says Srivatsan Jayashankar, Head of AR Partnerships at Snap Inc. In that one concise remark, he captures the essence of the company’s push into India’s dynamic AR or augmented reality ecosystem – which is nothing but bubbling with creative energy. Combine that with ambitious young developers and a culture of visual communication like few others on the planet, and Snap Inc – the parent company of Snapchat – has nothing but struck gold.

I caught up with Srivatsan at Snap Inc’s second annual India AR Day in Mumbai, an event that felt more like a festival of playful Lenses and hyperlocal experiences rather than your typical corporate summit. With the current tech discourse saturated with talk

about the next big tech wave or which app might dominate tomorrow, Snap’s approach seemed different – it’s all about empowering local creators to build AR experiences that resonate in real ways, with real people, across India and the subcontinent’s diverse cultures and communities.

Snap sees India as the next frontier of AR, according to Srivatsan Jayashankar, and they’re working to ensure that AR doesn’t just remain the domain of niche tech enthusiasts, but something that’s integral to daily life.

Building AR that reflects India

“India is a particularly interesting market for us. Our early investment here has led to huge adoption, especially with Gen Z,” Srivatsan tells me, referencing data that Snap’s dug up showing how Indian Gen Z loves to express themselves with filters, stickers, GIFs, and short videos.

Indeed, BCG Snap research suggests “four out of five Gen Z individuals in India use images, GIFs, and other immersive visuals to connect.”

That love for visual expression is exactly the sweet spot Snap is aiming for, building on its roots as a “camera company” that first became famous for ephemeral snaps and playful Lenses. Only now, the company’s going all-in on more advanced AR, bridging the gap from dog-face filters to real-time object recognition, brand try-on experiences, and hyperlocal geofilters.

A huge part of this exercise, Srivatsan explains, is making sure AR has local flavour and doesn’t feel like an import from a distant Western lab. “We really believe that AR should be a way to celebrate local culture and let people tell their own stories,” he says. “We’ve introduced AR Lenses for local festivals like Gudi Padva, Pongal, Durga Pooja, and Janmashtami.”

For a culturally rich country where every region has its own celebrations – from Onam in Kerala to Bhogali Bihu in Assam – AR can be a fun, expressive medium to highlight those moments. Srivatsan notes that Snap has rolled out more than 500 hyperlocal geofilters across the country, letting folks in different cities or towns see unique designs relevant to their own cultural identity. “We want AR to be relevant and meaningful in people’s lives,” he remarks, and the best way to do that is to meet people where they already are – heightening celebrations, community gatherings, and festivals.

And vindicating Snap’s decision to pay greater attention to the Indian market is visible in the following milestone, that India’s AR Developer community has grown by over 50% in two years, now boasting the highest number of AR Lenses globally. That’s a bold claim, but Srivatsan is good for it. “We’re putting a lot of effort into expanding AR adoption across the country, especially focusing on Tier 2 and 3 cities,” he says. “In 2024, we hosted 120+ meetups and connected with over 6,000 AR developers.” These workshops and meetups aren’t